

Regional Economic Comparison and Business Location Analysis

Executive summary:

This report analyzes socioeconomic conditions across 5 counties in Southern Ohio and Northern Kentucky to support business location decisions. This analysis uses census data and labor statistics to analyze median income, unemployment rates, and educational attainment. The results show that no county has the best of every metric, indicating tradeoffs between workforce education, income levels, and employment conditions. Greenup County is the best county for businesses requiring a highly educated workforce, while Pike and Jackson counties are the best for blue collar industries. Ross County offers a balanced environment for activities that combine blue collar and white collar work. These findings emphasize the importance of aligning business strategy with regional workforce characteristics.

Business problem: Regional stakeholders need a way to compare the economies across different counties in southern Ohio and Northern Kentucky, to determine which counties are best suited for different types of businesses, as in this report, we look at 5 counties: Ross County, Ohio, Pike County, Ohio, Scioto County, Ohio, Jackson County, Ohio, and Greenup County, Kentucky.

Approach: The datasets used to complete this task were county-level census data and county-level Bureau of Labor Statistics data. The tools I used to complete this were Tableau, Python, and a Streamlit dashboard. I used these approaches because they are interactive and decision-friendly. An interactive Streamlit dashboard was developed and deployed to allow stakeholders to dynamically explore county-level economic data.

Key findings: Ross County, Ohio, has the highest county median income at roughly \$61,000, while Scioto County, Ohio, has the lowest at roughly \$51,000. In terms of the unemployment rate, Greenup County, Kentucky, has the highest county unemployment rate at roughly 5.8%, while Scioto County, Ohio, has the lowest at roughly 4.1%. In terms of percent bachelor's degree attainment, Greenup County, Kentucky, has the highest amount at 18.8%, while Jackson County, Ohio, has the lowest at 15.9%. No single county outperforms others across all metrics, indicating trade-offs that must be considered when making business decisions. For businesses targeting blue collar workers, counties such as Jackson and Pike might be more suitable due to stronger employment conditions. In contrast, businesses requiring a more highly educated workforce may find Greenup County more attractive due to higher levels of bachelor's degree attainment. An unexpected notable finding was Greenup County having the highest bachelor's degree attainment percentage, considering that Greenup County, Kentucky, does not have any colleges within its boundaries, while Scioto County has Shawnee State University, and Ross County has Ohio University Chillicothe. A notable finding is that Scioto County has the lowest median income rate despite being one of the urbanized counties in the region.

Business implications: Greenup County is better positioned for white collar economic development, while Scioto County represents a mixed economic profile with strong employment but lower median income, suggesting concentration in lower wage industries. Pike County and Jackson County both target more blue-collar economic development, while Ross County, Ohio appears to have a balanced mix of targeting both blue-collar and white-collar economic development. Hence, these analyses suggest that different counties are suited for different types of economic development. Counties like Jackson and Pike which demonstrate relatively low unemployment rates, may be more attractive to businesses relying on steady amounts of blue-collar labor (e.g., working in lumber yards). By contrast, Greenup County, with a higher percentage of bachelor's degrees attained, may be better positioned to support businesses that require a more educated workforce (e.g. software designers). Ross County offers a balanced environment, making it a good county for mixed economic development that requires a healthy balance of college-educated and non-college-educated work (e.g., shipping companies that rely on both supply chain managers and truckers). Scioto County also represents a mixed economic profile with strong employment but lower median income, indicating that it is active but mainly in the lower-wage industries. It is important to match your business model to a specific county-wide workforce, rather than assuming a one-size-fits-all approach.

Recommendations:

1. Businesses targeting blue-collar consumers should consider locating in either Jackson County or Pike County due to their employment numbers being stronger.
2. Businesses requiring a more highly educated workforce should consider locating in Greenup County due to higher levels of bachelor's degree attainment.
3. Ross County is best for businesses seeking a balanced environment with moderate income levels and a healthy mix of blue-collar and white-collar jobs.
4. Stakeholders should utilize the interactive dashboard to evaluate new data about economic conditions.

This analysis demonstrates the value of data-driven decision making in regional economic planning and highlights the importance of aligning business strategy with local workforce characteristics.

References/Appendix:

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